

Advances in science

Science begins with problems. The world's great scientists were all thinkers who wanted to solve life's problems. This need for understanding has produced many great inventions and discoveries.

Johannes Gutenberg (1400–1468)

Gutenberg played a key role in printing. Experts believe he invented metal-type printing in Europe. Gutenberg's press was quick, accurate, and hard-wearing, compared to earlier woodblock printing.



Gutenberg's first printed book was the Bible in 1455.

1400

1500

1600

Wooden replica of da Vinci's Ornithopter.

Leonardo da Vinci (1452–1519)

Leonardo was a painter and inventor. He drew plans for helicopters, aeroplanes, and parachutes. Unfortunately, the technology of the time was not good enough to build any that worked.

Galileo Galilei (1564–1642)

Galileo proved that the Earth moves around the Sun by looking at the Solar System through a telescope. A few wise thinkers had always suspected the truth, but most people at the time believed that our Earth was the centre of everything.

Replica of a 17th-century telescope

Isaac Newton (1642–1727)

Newton investigated forces and light. He realized there must be a force that keeps the planets in orbit around the Sun. Today we know this as gravity. Newton also discovered that white light is made up of all the colours of the rainbow.

Stories suggest Newton discovered gravity with an apple.



Newton found that white light was made up of seven colours.